indeed have been for him. It was not for the milkman. The morning after the Legislative Assembly bomb blast, with the news having been reported in the press, the milkman sought out Jatin Das at his Hazara Road Mess and insisted on returning the rupee back to him so that it could be returned to Bhagat Singh, ‘as he felt honoured and proud to have served such a distinguished patriot’.[3]

A trial followed. It is important to remember that Bhagat Singh actually underwent three trials, and not one, and this is often not fully appreciated. Yet, it is necessary to keep these three trials distinct if one is to understand properly the steps leading up to his hanging in 1931. The first trial he faced was the Delhi Assembly Bomb Case trial, which began on 7 May 1929, and at the conclusion of which Bhagat Singh was not sentenced to death but faced transportation to the Andaman Islands for life. The second trial is the one he is most known for, and this is the Lahore Conspiracy Case, when together with Sukhdev Thapar and Shivram Rajguru, he was tried for the murder of J.P. Saunders, and when he was sentenced to death. This trial began initially before a regular magistrate by the name of Rai Sahib Pandit Sri Kishen on 10 July 1929. It ran for ten months. Over 200 witnesses were called for the prosecution. Then suddenly the trial was brought to an abrupt end and deferred to a special tribunal. This was set up under the governor-general’s Lahore Ordinance No. III of 1930 which was signed off on 1 May 1930 and which was to sit in Poonch House where the Lahore Civil Secretariat is presently located. Five days later it began to hear the rest of the case against the Lahore conspirators, beginning on 5 May 1930, rushing through the evidence and allowing no right of cross-examination to the defence counsel. At the end of this trial, Bhagat Singh was sentenced to death together with Sukhdev Thapar and Shivram Rajguru, on 7 October 1930. There was no right of appeal against the sentence of death from the special tribunal to the high court in Lahore, as there would have been from the magistrate’s court had it been allowed to complete the trial, and so the only appeal that could be exercised lay before the judicial committee of the Privy Council in London. This was the third trial and the least known and least commented upon.[4] It was argued only on a single day by the